

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-07-25

1 dear bahá'í friends,

2 concerning the extraordinary behavior of one of the delegates at your recent National convention.

how to deal with this situation would depend to some degree upon the

3 believer in question; for example, whether he is a new and inexperienced bahá'í or a long-time believer who would be expected to know better. This

4 is a matter within your jurisdiction, but if you require any further advice
5 provide it with more detailed information. in general it would, of course, be
6 desirable for you to try to clarify the principles for this friend and help him
7 to understand his responsibilities. At the same time you will wish to try to
8 ascertain the reasons for his behavior so that you can assist him to overcome
9 his problems.

10 To assist you in consulting with this friend, we enclose a few extracts
11 from passages relating to the responsibilities of delegates to a National bahá'í convention.

12 of all the responsibilities resting upon a delegate, that of voting for the
13 members of the National Spiritual Assembly is clearly the most weighty. in
14 carrying out this duty, the delegate must, prayerfully and conscientiously, vote for those whom he judges best fit the qualifications that the beloved guardian has outlined for those who are to serve on Spiritual Assemblies

15 and, in making this choice, he must be left free from every external influence by either individual believers or bahá'í institutions. if he states that
16 he has difficulty in thinking of nine bahá'ís who measure up to the high
17 standards mentioned, he could be referred to the following passage written on behalf of the guardian to a National Spiritual Assembly on 24 October
18 of the guardian to a National Spiritual Assembly on 24 October

19 1947:

in regard to your question about qualifications of delegates and

20 Assembly members: the qualifications which he outlined are really ap-185.1

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186 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

187 06plicable to anyone we elect to a bahá'í office, whatever its nature. but

188 these are only an indication, they do not mean people who don't fulfill

them cannot be elected to office. we must aim as high as we can. he

does not feel the friends should attach so much importance to limi-

189 tations—such as people perhaps not being able to attend Assembly or convention
meetings, because if they do, then the fundamental

concept of everyone being willing to do bahá'í service on administra-

190 tive bodies will be weakened, and the friends may be tempted to vote for those who
because of independent means or circumstances in their lives are freer to come and go but
less qualified to serve.

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192 for a delegate to walk out of the convention hall at the time of the elec-

193 tion would seem to indicate a disdain for the electoral process and a public

194 abdication of his responsibilities, which would be quite improper. it is en-

195 tirely within the authority of the National Spiritual Assembly to inquire the

196 reason for such extraordinary behavior, inasmuch as it has the responsibility for the
proper conduct of the convention.

197 furthermore, one of the responsibilities of a delegate is to report back

198 from the convention to the district by which he was elected. if this particu-

199 lar delegate does not explain to his electors the reason for his failure to vote, your
Assembly would be fully entitled to report the occurrence to them.

200 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

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Visit to the Bahá'í World Center

by the President of the Seychelles

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]